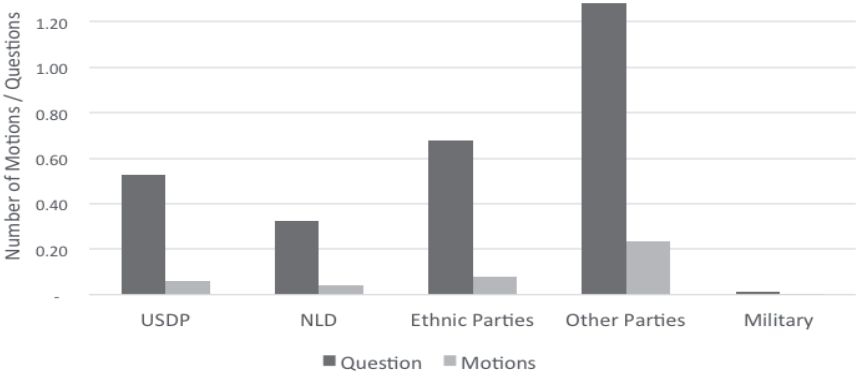
choice for the legislators was questions and motions, which they could table to the legislature subject to approval of the speaker. Figure 10.2 represents the frequency of the use of questions and motions from 2011 to 2014.

Figure 10.2. Questions and motions, 2011–14 (per session, per legislator)



Legislators usually started their attempts by raising questions, and tabled them as motions when they felt more confident. Questions were usually addressed to the executive for explanation and confirmation but they are not binding. A motion is a lot more difficult and takes more time to prepare than a question. It must pass a number of steps: approval from the speaker, approval from the legislature to be debated as a motion, and a vote passed as a motion. In addition, motions are regarded as legislative oversight of the executive and the latter is required to implement them, though there is no constitutional measure to force compliance. Because of over-reliance on questions and motions and because of the indirect nature of legislative tools (that is, through the executive), the legislature had little influence dealing with the conflict, as in the case of the peace process and communal violence. Moreover, on fast-moving issues like communal violence and the Letpadaung conflict, there is no way the legislature can react to the changing situation in real time. But because it can exert constitutional pressure on the executive, it has a strong oversight influence as seen in land-grabbing issues.

Other than these tools, public complaints and petitions proved to be the main sources of collecting information from the public. When speaking with the Public Complaints and Petition Committee of the Amyotha Hluttaw during my fieldwork in March 2014, I was told that